

Tosan Case Study - Design System Strategy

Case Study: Tosan Design System

Building a Unified Architecture for 15+ Enterprise Banking Products

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Role: Lead Product Designer (Design System & Strategy)

Timeline: 2021 – 2024

Domain: FinTech / Enterprise Banking

1. Executive Summary

Tosan is a leading provider of electronic banking infrastructure in Iran, managing a massive ecosystem of over 15 banking products across 8 independent teams. Before this initiative, each team operated in a silo, leading to fragmented user experiences, massive technical debt, and inefficient delivery cycles.

I was tasked with architecting and leading the development of a scalable, Atomic Design System to unify the entire product suite, reduce design-to-code friction, and ensure brand consistency across all platforms.

2. The Challenge

The lack of a shared design language resulted in:

- Inconsistency: Over 150+ UI variations for the same functional components, such as buttons, inputs, and modals.

- Redundancy: Designers and developers were reinventing the wheel for every new feature, doubling time-to-market.
 - Maintenance Debt: Updating a single brand asset required manual changes across 15+ separate codebases.
 - Fragmented UX: Users experienced different interaction patterns when moving between Tosan products.
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3. My Role & Strategy

As the Lead Product Designer, I owned the end-to-end strategy of the Design System:

- Audit & Research: Evaluated 300+ Figma files and 15 products to identify commonalities and conflicts.
 - Architecture: Designed a three-layer Atomic Core System: Base Tokens → Core Components → Patterns.
 - Standardization: Defined specifications for 150+ interactive components.
 - Governance: Established a Contribution Model to allow teams to suggest and update components without breaking the core.
 - Collaboration: Acted as the bridge between 8 product teams, PMs, and frontend engineers.
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4. The Process: From Audit to Governance

Phase A: The UI Audit

I conducted a deep dive into existing products, categorizing components by usage frequency and complexity. This revealed that 60% of design time was spent on repetitive UI tasks that could be automated or standardized.

Phase B: System Architecture (The Atomic Approach)

I built the system using a modular architecture:

1. Design Tokens: Centralized color palettes, typography scales, spacing, and elevation.
2. Core Components: Built highly flexible, accessible, and state-aware components, including inputs, buttons, tables, and data grids.
3. Complex Patterns: Standardized multi-step banking flows, such as transaction verification and multi-factor authentication.

Phase C: Documentation & Hand-off

I implemented a robust documentation portal that included:

- Usage guidelines, including do's and don'ts
- Interaction specs and motion behaviors
- Code parity details for developers
- Accessibility (a11y) standards for enterprise banking

5. Key Challenges & Solutions

- Challenge: Resistance from established teams who feared losing creative freedom.

Solution: Conducted weekly System Syncs and demonstrated how the system frees up their time for high-level UX problem solving rather than pixel-pushing.

- Challenge: Technical diversity across React, Angular, and legacy frameworks.

Solution: Focused on framework-agnostic design tokens and clear CSS/HTML specs to ensure visual parity.

6. Impact & Results (KPIs)

The implementation of the Tosan Core System delivered measurable business value:

- 40% Reduction in Design Redundancy: Teams stopped creating UI from scratch.
 - 25% Increase in Delivery Speed: Drastically shortened the design-to-dev handoff cycle.
 - 30% UX Consistency Improvement: Measured by cross-product UI audits and user feedback.
 - 150+ Standardized Components: Serving 15+ products and 8 multidisciplinary teams.
 - Unified Brand Identity: Successfully aligned all enterprise products under one cohesive visual language.
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7. Conclusion & Lessons Learned

This project taught me that a Design System is 20% design and 80% people and process. Success wasn't just about the Figma library; it was about building a culture of collaboration across 8 different teams. It reinforced the importance of DesignOps in large-scale enterprise environments and how a well-structured system can be a significant competitive advantage.

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